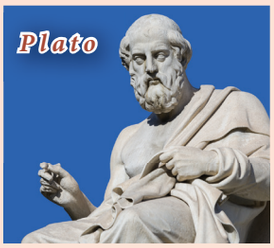
UNIT 7

Political Thought

7.1 Plato

(428/427 – 348/347 BCE)

- ***Socrates's* Student**
- **Founded the Academy-** First institution for higher education.
- **First Western philosopher** whole writings have survived
- **Most of what we know about** Socrates comes from ***Plato***'s writings
- **Agreed with Pythagoras that Mathematics were essential in understanding the world.**



Learning Objectives

- To understand the Political thought of ***Plato***.
- To apply in the present context.
- To gain knowledge about ***Plato***'s ideas on state, government, Justice, Education, Communism.

Plato was born in 427/428 BCE. He belonged to an aristocratic family in Athens a Greek City State. ***Plato's*** real name was ***'Aristocles'***. Some historical sources say his wrestling coach Ariston of Argos dubbed him 'Platon' meaning 'Broad' on account of his large build. He was a disciple of ***Socrates*** who was one of the foremost philosophers of Greece. During his time there was great chaos in the political life of Athens which was a Greek City State. This resulted in the Athenian government condemning ***Socrates*** to death because of his teachings. This greatly affected ***Plato's*** views on politics especially in Athens.

In about 387 BCE ***Plato*** founded his 'Academy'. The name 'Academy' comes from the name of a famous Athenian hero called 'Akademos'. Here ***Plato*** taught Political Philosophy which contained politics, ethics, mathematics and sociology.

Plato's Works

The three most important works of ***Plato*** are 'The Republic' (386 BCE), 'The Statesman' (360 BCE) and 'The Laws' (347 BCE). Apart from these works, he has written a number of other smaller books.

Plato's Thought

The important ideas of ***Plato*** are found in his three major works and can be summarised as follows:

Ideal State

In Political Science, the most important concept around which the subject is built is 'The State'. According

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